Persia was under threat from a Bolshevik invasion, arguing that Lenin's regime was as yet unable to organise an operation on such a large scale as would be necessary to successfully attack Persia. As Curzon's irritation appeared at breaking point, Cecil aptly summed up Britain's policy in Persia as being 'neither fish, flesh, fowl, nor good red herring'.[62]

The meeting of 19 December had shown a preference among the majority of committee members to remain distanced from Persian affairs. Curzon, nonetheless, had not been deterred from pursuing a more forward policy and two days after the meeting he received support for his endeavours from Sir Louis Mallet, ex-ambassador to Constantinople and current head of the Middle East section of the Political Intelligence Department (PID) at the Foreign Office.[63] In a memorandum written on 21 December, Mallet argued that to abandon Persia, as Montagu, Cecil and Grant had suggested, would have grave consequences for British interests in Mesopotamia, Afghanistan and India. It would also leave Persia entirely open to Russian advances, be it Bolshevik or White Russian. Mallet's proposal was for Britain, in effect, to go on the offensive and extend its influence into the northern regions. He argued that were Britain not to press forward into 'so fertile a field, just at the moment when our principle [sic] rival has disappeared from the scene... a good opportunity would be missed'. Mallet emphasised, in particular, the urgency of exploiting Russia's current weakness before it was able to re-organise and re-assert its authority in Persia. Echoing Cox, Mallet advised gaining a mandate for Persia, in order to allow Britain to 'fortify ourselves against any possible future difficulties with Russia'.[64]

It just so happened that Mallet's thinking was perfectly inline with that of Curzon and of Cox and his memorandum gave added impetus to their cause. At the heart of their argument lay the idea that Britain needed to extend and consolidate its position in Persia as quickly as possible, before the traditional enemy, Russia (be it Bolshevik or otherwise), could regain its influence there. Not only was the possibility of a revived imperial Russia seriously discussed in 1918, but it was actually used by the likes of Cox and Mallet to emphasise the need for haste in this direction. Furthermore, the presence of vestigial elements of imperial Russia in Persia after the 1917 revolution could hardly go unnoticed, given that Britain was financially supporting most of them. Even the post-war concept of seeking a mandate